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The Viking Age is the period during the Middle Ages when Scandinavian Norsemen explored, raided, and traded from their Scandinavian homelands across wide areas of northern, central, and eastern Europe, during the late 8th to late 11th centuries. This period of Scandinavian military, mercantile and demographic expansion is an important part of European history. The Viking Age began dramatically on June 8, 793, with the raid on the monastery at Lindisfarne in Northumbria. This attack on a Christian holy site shocked the medieval world and marked the beginning of two centuries of Viking activity across Europe. Vikings were not just raiders but also traders, explorers, and settlers. They established trade routes from Scandinavia to the Byzantine Empire and the Abbasid Caliphate. Norse merchants dealt in furs, timber, iron, and slaves, trading for silver, silk, spices, and wine. The Vikings were master shipbuilders and navigators. Their longships were technological marvels—fast, flexible, and capable of sailing in both deep ocean waters and shallow rivers. These vessels enabled Vikings to raid inland sites and cross the Atlantic to reach Iceland, Greenland, and North America. Leif Erikson's expedition to North America around 1000 AD, centuries before Columbus, established a short-lived settlement at L'Anse aux Meadows in Newfoundland. This makes the Vikings the first Europeans known to have reached the Americas.

Viking society was complex and sophisticated. Despite their reputation as brutal warriors, Vikings had rich cultural traditions, including intricate poetry, mythology, and craftsmanship. Their legal systems and democratic assemblies influenced European political development. The conversion to Christianity dramatically changed Viking society. By the mid-11th century, the Scandinavian kingdoms had adopted Christianity, integrated with European Christian culture, and the era of pagan Viking raids ended. The Battle of Stamford Bridge in 1066 is often considered the end of the Viking Age. Viking influence remains visible today in place names, languages, laws, and cultural practices across Europe. English contains numerous words of Norse origin, and many European cities were founded or shaped by Viking settlement.